

IT CORRIDOR

Adyar » Kanathur » Kelambakkam » Navalur » Semmencherry » Thoraipakkam » Velachery » IIT Madras » Kandanchavadi » Kottivakkam

Neelankarai » Sholinganallur » Thiruvannamiyur » Vijaya Nagar » Indira Nagar » Karapakkam » Kotturpuram » Padur » Thalambur » Pallikarai



THE PINK ROUTE TO EMPOWERING WOMEN

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos to beneficiaries it has selected with a fine-tooth comb. **P6**



THE SWAP CODE

Welcome to three online groups started by sustainability enthusiast and volunteer Swathi Ramanathan from Kasturba Nagar in Adyar. **P4**



The bus stop near First Cross Street, Kasturba Nagar and (below) the one near Second Cross Street, Kasturba Nagar. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Replace this manhole in Perungudi’

L. SUNDARARAMAN

Anna High Road in Perungudi, adjacent to the Perungudi lake, bustles through the day, which is what makes the damaged manhole in the centre of this road deadly.

The damaged manhole poses a threat to the safety of road users navigating this section, particularly at night when it is easy to miss it. Early replacement could save lives.

L. Sundararaman is a resident of Perungudi

The damaged manhole on Anna High Road in Perungudi.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



‘Provide posts indicating these two bus stops in Adyar’

C. NAMACHIVAYAM

Bus commuters boarding buses at the two bus stops on Sardar Patel road in Adyar (one near First Cross Street Kasturba Nagar and the other near Second Cross Street Kasturba Nagar) would

find it immensely helpful if “bus stop posts” are installed with the bus route numbers.

Every day hundreds of bus passengers suffer because they do not know the locations of route numbers.

MTC officials are aware of this problem but need help in the in-

stallation of the posts. Funds had been already allocated for shelters.

At least part of the funds can be used for putting up the posts. These are needed for buses going towards Madhya Kailash.

(C. Namachivayam is a resident of Indira Nagar)



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Water hyacinth saves lives at Ottiyambakkam quarry

The Ottiyambakkam panchayat had a harrowingly difficult time keeping people from swimming in the deadly quarry with its protruding rocks hidden under the waters. There had been many deaths. And then nature intervened, and the fatal accidents stopped. An invasive, floating weed that is a bane of water sources, the water hyacinth is not just tolerated in the quarry but welcomed



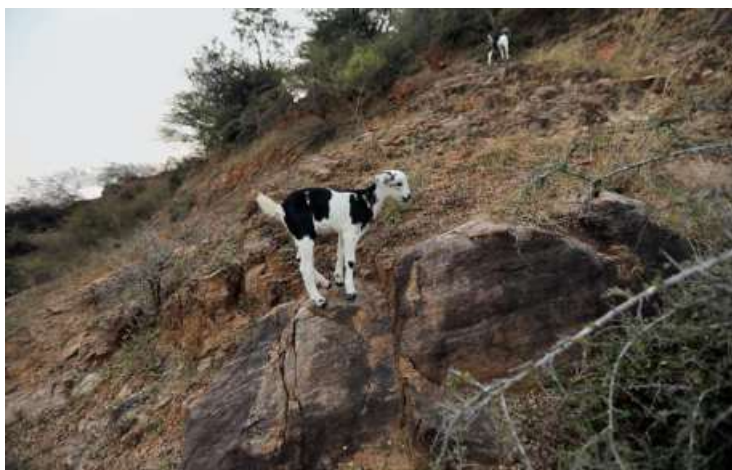
The waters at the abandoned quarry in Ottiyambakkam overrun with water hyacinth, which serves as a life saver in this context; the street along the quarry marked by a row of saplings now; a goat kid on the flanks; and an expansion project pertaining to a temple on the summit of the hillock that constitutes the abandoned quarry. The images were taken on March 21, 2026. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

PRINCE FREDERICK

What you see in Ottiyambakkam is straight out of Lawley Road in R.K. Narayan's delectably imaginary, pint-sized but variegated universe, Malgudi. In a post-Independence, post-colonial environment, efforts to recast roads in a native mould, specifically their names, a populist obsession that continues to this very day and minute, reach Malgudi with Sir Frederick Lawley's statue being removed intact from Lawley Road before the renaming of the thoroughfare. After the statue is lifted off its footings (in fact, blasted with dynamite, safely though), fresh information about Lawley's immense contribution to Malgudi's growth surfaces, causing a change of heart. The mood now shifts to: Lawley Road should continue as Lawley Road and the British official's life-size statue live on in Malgudi.

Superimpose that idea upon the abandoned Ottiyambakkam quarry, where a carpet of green woven with water hyacinth spreads across the waters.

Water hyacinth, an antagonist in water sources everywhere, plays a do-gooder role in the Ottiyambakkam quarry alone. Detested and met with calls for its removal in lakes and waterways, in the waters of the abandoned Ottiyambakkam



quarry the water hyacinth has found a home where it is not just tolerated but welcomed.

Here is how the water hyacinth stepped into this new role.

Of the abandoned quarries in and around Chennai, the one in Ottiyambakkam is probably the most diminutive, and decidedly the most dangerous. A magnet for ad-

venture seekers, the quarry has witnessed many revellers accidentally dash their heads against the jutting crags hidden waters while diving in for a swim. Accessible via what is called Mount Street, this quarry was a source of headache for the local Ottiyambakkam panchayat, its many warning boards yelling at these adventure seekers to stay off these waters, but the harsh warning was being received with leaden ears. The fatal accidents continued, and then it stopped due to an unexpected turn of events. The warning boards have gone, having become glaringly redundant.

What the warnings and monitoring by the local civic body could not achieve was managed silently by a quirky act of nature. For quite some time now the quarry has been unusable by weekend revellers for swimming and by local residents for cloth-washing, thanks to a proliferation of water hyacinth. How long this quarry is in a state where water hyacinth has covered the entire expanse of the waters depends on the lips commenting on it. A small time trader in these parts thinks it should be nearly two years, if not more.

The floating water hyacinth is an invasive species and its spread has a deleterious effect on water sources, and the living organisms in them. It is definitely a problem to be dealt with wherever it is found,

but certainly not in the Ottiyambakkam quarry. If one does a cost-benefit analysis (the benefits being lives saved), leaving the water hyacinth alone and thriving would be a judicious idea. At the foot of the half-cut hillock, on the street, saplings encased in tree guards stand. They are pleasant substitutes for the warning boards that were hollering in vain.

The rear section of the hillock, the uncut portion, is as busy as ever, as it holds a temple in the crook of its palm. A winding cement road leading up to the temple is accustomed to the brush of feet and tyres, both in units of two and four. Cars sweep effortlessly to the summit. People mill around the surface of the hillock, so do livestock. On the flanks, expect to watch a tennis-ball cricket match being played on, rough uneven ground, the ball bouncing off boulders. A straight on the winding cement road serves as pitch. There is movement of livestock, particularly goats feeding on the vegetation on the flanks of the hillock. The surface area of the temple at the summit being increased through an expansion project, long blocks of stones have been stationed and they are in different stages of carving.

From the summit, the sight of the setting, orangish sun hovering over the hillocks in Kumizhi and surrounding areas in the west is arresting.

Mega career counselling fair on April 11 and 12

Conducted by
The Hindu
EducationPlus,
the fair is in its
23th edition

The *Hindu Education-Plus* is conducting the 23rd edition of The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair 2026 on April 11 and 12 from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the Chennai Trade Centre, Convention Hall.

The exhaustive fair for parents and students from classes 9 to 12 will empower aspiring young minds to make informed career decisions from 40 plus institutions and help them choose the right courses and colleges. Top educational and financial institutions from across India will be present. Furthermore, career guidance sessions with domain experts will help people dis-

cuss their career plans.

This annual fair is a great chance for students and parents to explore different career paths, learn about college admissions, and gain insights into various fields of

study.

A plethora of options awaits students as they get ready to finish their schooling, much more than ever before. There is a wide range of courses to choose from,

careers to aspire to, and areas of interest to delve into. In every edition, the fair has aimed to give students insights into several areas, cater to their interests, and open a world of educational opportunities for them.

The latest edition of the career Counselling fair will have all of this and make this experience possible for students by giving them the platform to engage with experts across diverse fields and representatives from various educational and financial institutions. Keeping up with the needs of the students, *The Hindu Education-*

Plus has been organising career expos to aid students looking to pursue higher education both in India and overseas.

Spot admissions and scholarships await the students at the fair along with surprise gifts for the first 200 entries on both the days. To know more about the sessions and the fair, contact: +91 90940 41021, 9962226550 and 9841298938.

“VIT Chennai presents The Hindu - Education Plus Career Counselling Fair 2026” is powered by Hindustan Group of Institutions,

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REPRESENTATIONAL PICTURE



Small buses sought near MRTS station on Velachery to St. Thomas Mount line

A small bus network that manages coverage of neighbourhoods within a four-kilometre radius of the Puzhuthivakkam railway station would be hugely beneficial to commuters

GUNASEKARAN S

The extension of the MRTS railway line from Velachery to St. Thomas Mount railway station is just what the doctor ordered for the many neighbourhoods around Puzhuthivakkam Railway station. It have provided residents in these interior pockts with a quick and convenient travelling option. The full benefit of this provision can be reaped if the “last mile” is also taken care of.

These neighbourhoods are located within a radius of three to four kilometres from the Puzhuthivakkam station and a small bus network in these parts would help commuters reach the facility without much of a hassle. To say this value add would do senior citizens great service is to state the obvious.

Here are a couple of options for MTC to mull over.

Route number 1 - Balaiah Garden to Puzhuthivakkam Railway Station- (via) Balaiah Garden-Padmathy Road-Thilakar Avenue 2nd Street-Otteri Salai-Ponni-



man Koil Road-Pillayar Koil-Bajanai Koil-Puzhuthivakkam bus stand.

Route number 2 - Madipak-

kam Bus stand to Puzhuthivakkam Railway station (via) Ponniammant Koil-Otteri Salai junction-Pillaiyar koil-Bajanai

Koil (Erikarrai school)-Puzhuthivakkam bus stand.

Gunasekaran S is a resident of Puzhuthivakkam

Selection for MUN Europe

Speak Your Mind is organising the ‘MUN Europe Selection Programme’ to identify students who can represent India at an international conference. The selection rounds will be held on May 15 and 16 at Career Launcher, Alwarpet.

The top 10 delegates will be selected to represent India at MUN Europe, scheduled to take place in Malta from October 7-9, 2026, said a release.

This initiative aims to provide students with global exposure and build skills in diplomacy, public speaking, and leadership.

For more details, visit: www.symedu.in

Contact: 8056024029

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The *swap* code

This has nothing to do with computer programming, but with an initiative that encourages participants to consider doing a swap on household items that might have outgrown their home but still has a place in somebody else's. Welcome to three online groups started by sustainability enthusiast and volunteer Swathi Ramanathan from Kasturba Nagar in Adyar

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Perfectly usable furniture, electronic goods, utensils and books often end up discarded because households have outgrown them. While volunteering for waste collection drives Kasturba Nagar resident Swathi Ramanathan regularly came across this anomaly and felt prompted to start two online groups, both with a WhatsApp and Telegram presence, that encourage swapping over shopping, wherever that is possible, and give gently used household items and books a new address where they are cherished all over again. In addition, following a discussion in one of these swap groups, she also formed a group where participants can learn about free wellness programmes much before they are rolled out.

Swap Don't Shop

At last count, around 1,500 residents of Chennai follow that imperative, always asking themselves whether they can swap and not shop. A WhatsApp-based initiative that spilled over to Telegram, the group enables swapping of household goods. Born on 15 July 2024 in WhatsApp, where it has hit the ceiling being packed with 1025 members, Swap Don't Shop has had to find an additional home in Telegram, where it commands the following of over 500 members. The author of the initiative, Kasturba Nagar resident Swathi Ramanathan, felt the need for this group while coordinating waste collection drives as a volunteer of Residents of Kasturba Nagar Association (ROKA). During these drives, she repeatedly noticed items still in good condition being discarded. "We saw many usable household items being thrown away. We believe a product has to be used till its lifetime comes to an end," says Swathi. Initially launched as a clothes exchange group by Swathi along with Vaishnavi Venkatesh, the platform was later expanded to include all household items after the early model failed to gain traction.

Transactions follow clear guidelines: only household items without expiry dates are allowed, and plants are welcomed. Members post photos with detailed descriptions, including brand, age, dimensions, condition, price, and pickup location. Delivery is coordinated directly between

buyer and seller, occasionally involving porters for larger items. The platform has enabled beneficiaries ranging from domestic help needing textbooks and study guides to expatriates seeking short-term household items like Golu dolls. While logistical challenges, pricing issues, and trust concerns occasionally arise, Swathi believes the initiative finds itself sustained by a sense of community and purpose felt by members.

Chennai Book Bridge

Chennai Book Bridge is a Diwali gift to those who still swear by the physical book, while also consuming information digitally. Again, the idea of starting this group occurred to Swathi during waste collection drives. She came across many people who wanted to part with their books, but only with those who will cherish those books. She decided on starting a book-swapping WhatsApp group, which has now grown to nearly 300 members, most of whom are senior citizens and regular readers who prefer physical books. Beyond book exchange and donations, the group encourages discussions on authors, genres, literary events, and book-to-film adaptations, creating an interactive reading community. Swathi notes that these discussions have become a defining feature. "It is a lovely group... there are so many things I myself didn't know about authors and books," she says.

Although a Telegram version was introduced to organise discussions by genre, participation remains stronger on WhatsApp due to the older user base. Challenges, such as reselling low-value books or managing occasional rude behaviour, are moderated with clear guidelines emphasising good faith. Swathi elaborates, "We cannot control everything, but we ensure the platform remains respectful and focused on reading."

Nalam Chennai Wellness Connect

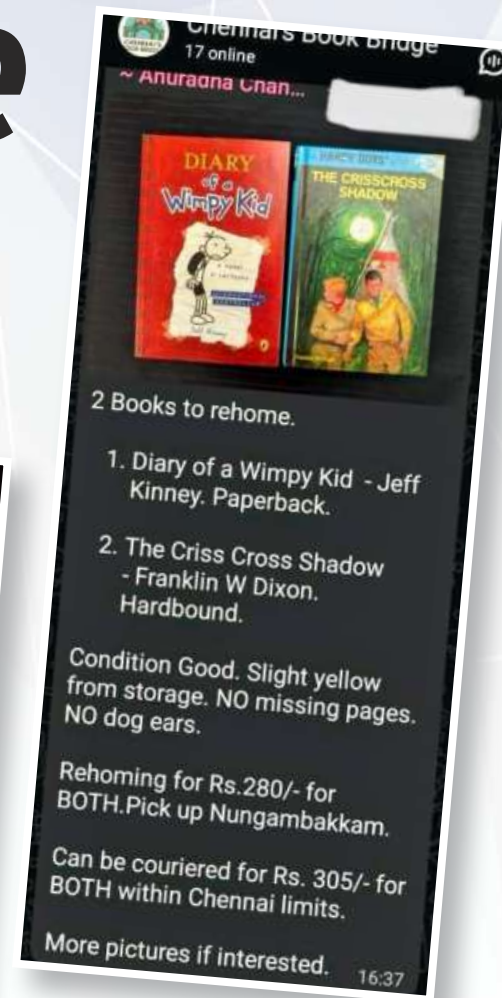
Free wellness camps have a way of eluding timely notice. Often times, they come to light as a post-event report in a website or a newspaper. Nalam Chennai Wellness Connect, present on WhatsApp and Telegram group, is an effort to bring visibility to free wellness programmes (yoga classes, health camps and so on) much before they start rolling so that people can attend and benefit from

them. Free yoga classes, free health camps

The idea began as an offshoot of the Swap Don't Shop initiative. "We wanted to brainstorm with participants about their interests. One of the interests was the wellness group. They said they wanted to know more about what was happening in the city in terms of wellness."

Members themselves can share details of free wellness services, provided the information is authentic. Swathi has shared updates on government initiatives, like free HPV vaccinations for adolescents. Currently, the group has 87 members on WhatsApp and 21 on Telegram, forming a small but growing network connecting Chennai residents to wellness opportunities that won't cost them a rupee.

For joining any of these groups, contact Swathi Ramanathan at 93812 02054



Against the backdrop of poll activity, a 400-metre stretch of an arterial road in Madurapakkam panchayat under Tambaram assembly constituency presents a salute to the idea of *res publica*, which underpins India's system of governance, where citizens have a say, at least before a government is securely ensconced in the seat of power. A Republic Day initiative, it shines bright every night on this stretch in Kovilancherry

A representation of the Tricolour rises above party flags

PRINCE FREDERICK

On the campaign trail in Tamil Nadu, rhetoric is being whetted to a cutting edge, as always happens when the trail draws near the home stretch. Partisan flag-waving is taking on greater vigour. And parties are wooing citizens with the end-phase desperation of a hopeful suitor.

Amidst all of this intense activity, this 400-metre stretch of an arterial road in the outskirts of Chennai (technically in the Tambaram assembly constituency) presents a silent, but colourful reminder of the first principles underpinning India's system of governance, where citizens have a say, at least before a government is securely ensconced in the seat of power, vis-a-vis their vote.

Essentially, it is a continuing gesture honouring the idea of *res publica* (a republic serving the collective citizens' good) and the colours of the tricolour, instituted this Republic Day (January 26, 2026) in a rather offbeat manner in a local panchayat. The gesture shines bright after evenfall.

It is a 400-metre stretch of Mambakkam-Medavakkam Main Road running through Kovilancherry in Madurapakkam panchayat, part of the Tambaram assembly constituency. On January 26, the hallowed colours were "unfurled" with LED neon flexes on the lampposts in the median.

Since then, this stretch has been offering a salute to the Flag of all flags and by extension, the Indian republic. As the lamps come on, the flexes sinuously coiling up on the lamp posts come to live, transmitting a image of tricolour through lighting. The flex on one lamppost has fallen silent, but all others continue to the speak the language of patriotism.

Motorists' manifesto

If motorists passing through the stretch were asked to pen in a manifesto, they might demand that post Assembly-polls, they would want this section of the arterial road (managed by the State Highways) relaid. Due to a civic infra work, part of the road lacks bitumen topping. Besides, they would want more of the carriageway for moving vehicles than parked vehicles.

The specially lit lamp posts at Kovilancherry on Mambakkam-Medavakkam Main Road. PHOTO: PRINCE FREDERICK

RWA submits petition about roads

Nesamani Nagar Residents' Welfare Association (NNRWA) in Perumbakkam has submitted a petition to the Tamil Nadu Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department to lay roads in the region under the Prime Minister Gram Sadak Yojana scheme.

The scheme commits to building roads in areas that have not experienced any development work.

N. K. Raja, president of NNRWA, says, "There are many roads in the region that are yet to be laid. The Perumbakkam Village Panchayat has sent a letter requesting an estimate for road laying."

The Department can secure the funds under the scheme after discussing the matter with the Prime Minister's Office in New Delhi and take up work. "The roads should be constructed in Golden Castle Layout, Perumbakkam," he added.



A road in Radha Nagar, Perumbakkam after the rains. PHOTO: R. RAVINDRAN

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The pink route to empowering women

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos to beneficiaries it has selected with a fine-tooth comb

LIFFY THOMAS

These bright pink autos have become a familiar sight on Chennai roads. Driven by women and catering primarily to women and children, pink autos are on the rise thanks to various social organisations and a scheme promoted by the Social Welfare and Women Empowerment Department of the Tamil Nadu Government to fund women (partially, in most cases) to own and drive these vehicles.

The pink fleet ticks several boxes: women empowerment, women's participation in the labour force, promoting a clean environment (CNG is used as fuel) and breaking gender stereotypes.

According to ballpark figure, Chennai must be having more than 500 pink women autorickshaw drivers and this number is only on the rise.

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos, close to 27 (its second major drive after it launched the project in August 2025 to distribute 100 pink autos in an event held at Chennai Trade Centre).

The District engages the service of ANEW (Association for Non-Traditional Employment for Women) to identify and train deserving women. Basics of martial arts and communication skills are also covered under the training.

"Our beneficiaries have to update us at least once a month about the status of their EMIs. So far, we have 85 who are prompt in doing that," says Siva Ilango van, chairman - Pink Auto Project, Rotary District 3234.

Supporting drivers

Rotary District 3233 initiated the Pink Auto Project in 2019 and till date has given away 153 autos for women. Rotarian Shanthi Sel-



(Right) Shanthi Selvam, chairperson of the Pink Auto Project, Rotary District 3233, with a beneficiary. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Under the project, women auto drivers train aspiring candidates. "Jothi Lakshmi, for instance, one of our first beneficiaries has trained many women, many a time spending money from her own pocket and has bought her own house with her income. Likewise, Saritha from Ashok Nagar goes to other localities to offer classes," she says.

To ensure these women have a steady income, the Club associates with various Interact and Rotract Clubs.

"Rotary Club of Madras North West is under our umbrella. We connected Selvi, residing in the area, with the Club who was put in touch with Velankanni School in Ashok Nagar that has an Interact Club. Students who needed transport now use her service," says Shanthi.

Associating with a social organisation also means these women enjoy other benefits. "Rajan Eye Hospital has tied up with us to offer free eye care for all pink auto drivers and their families, including funding their cataract surgeries," says Shanthi.

Tough rules

According to Tamil Nadu Motor Vehicle Rules, only women are authorised to operate pink autos. To be eligible to apply for an auto under the Pink Auto scheme of the State Government, a woman must be between 20 and 45 years of age. P.V. Raji Ashok, a senior auto driver from Perambur, feels having a cut-off restricts many deserving women from entering the field.

She also feels it is unfair to take action if pink autos are operated by men. "My neighbour met with an accident the day she brought the pink auto and could not drive for six months. How will she repay the loan?" she asks.

There should be some authority these women can approach to seek exception when they cannot drive for genuine reasons, says Raji, who has been an auto driver since 1998.

vam, who has been chairperson of the project since its inception, says one of the biggest success stories of the project is that none of its women beneficiaries have sold their autos despite various challenges on and off the road. That is because they follow a rigorous process in selecting the most deserving persons (single women and widows are accorded preference in the selection process) and support them till they manage a steady income. Driving these vehicles is a big step toward financial independence for these women.

Of the ₹3 lakh purchase cost of an auto run on CNG, 50 percent is

borne by the Rotary District and the rest by the beneficiary who takes a bank loan, which is to be repaid by her in instalments.

"For women whose CIBIL score does not qualify them for a loan, we arrange for the loan by tying up with a private financial institution," says Shanthi, adding that they give away pink autos as and when they find sponsors.

"Finding sponsors is a challenge, and we have not reached out for CSR funds," she says adding that these women can earn between ₹1,500 and ₹2,000 a day.



For women whose CIBIL score does not qualify them for a loan, we arrange for the loan by tying up with a private financial institution



'Deploy police personnel under the Medavakkam flyover'



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

The meeting point of Classical Language Road and Velachery Main Road and its precincts in Medavakkam can at times get chaotic.

On the lane towards Pallikaranai, motorists intending to proceed on the eastern lane of the Main Road (towards Madambakkam Main Road) and Classical Language Road should take a U-turn near the Medavakkam farmers market. But, they drive along the Medavakkam haltover (towards Tambaram (East and West) and Kilambakkam.

Only motorists from Classical Language Road and Velachery Main Road (eastern lane) towards Pallikaranai can navigate this.

"This causes congestion on Classical Language Road and Velachery Main Road," says B. Haritha Babu, a rider. Traffic is disrupted on Vela-



Motorists drive in the wrong direction to enter Velachery Main Road and Classical Language Road. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

chery Main Road, the lane towards Pallikaranai, as a good number of vehicle users wait to move in the opposite direction.

Motorists speed and swerve right and left. Motorists on Velachery Main Road, the lane towards Pallikaranai, should not turn right, but when they

see their counterparts taking a turn, they stop their vehicles all of a sudden to follow them. This can lead to multiple collisions on Velachery Main Road, adds Haritha.

"Traffic police personnel must be deployed here to curb this practice and prevent accidents."

Vocational awards presented

Rotary Club of Chennai Tower, a unit of Rotary International District 3233, organised its annual vocational service award event recently.

According to a press release, N Silambarasan, better known as "Silambarasu Silambu" from Ponneri was presented with Vocational Service Award - Young Achiever in Sports in recognition of his expertise in martial art, Silambarasu. The Vocational Service Award - Social Service was presented to Selvakumar, a tailor from Virudhunagar. He has trained a large number of underprivileged women in tailoring with an aim to empower them for a fee of ₹1. S Padma, a 48-year-old conservancy worker from Chennai was pre-



sented with Vocational Service Award - Epitome of Ethics Icon for the prompt return of 45 sovereigns of gold jewellery that she discovered during her duty. The award aims to honour her exceptional honesty.

Nimal Raghavan, an engineer-turned-environmentalist, was ho-

noured for his work on conservation of lakes. He was presented with Vocational Service Award - Environmental Preservation.

Vocational Service Award - Lifetime Achievement was presented to Bharatanatyam exponent Leela Samson, adds the release.

Admission on at school in Thiruvanniyur

Admission is on at M School Kindergarten in Thiruvanniyur.

The school, a wing of Aasaan EduCare Initiative, offers Montessori methodology of education.

According to a press release, the school has crafted a comprehensive childcare ecosystem that extends well beyond conventional day care hours.

Also, extended daycare services from 5.30 p.m. to 9 p.m. are available.

The school offers digital monitoring of student entry and exit that enable parents to track their child's attendance in real-time.

Reports on health, developmental milestones, and daily activities are digitalised.

The school is located at 44/7, Lattice Bridge Road, Thiruvanniyur.

For details, call 98406 71046/ 8799959993 / 98406 70023 / 044 35260303.

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